

HR FOR EVERY MANAGER

*The Complete People Management Playbook for Line Managers, Team
Leaders, and Business Leaders with People Responsibility*

MAYUR N KOIKAR

The HR Mastery Series™ by Mayur N Koikar — Book 8

HR for Every Manager™

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To every manager who takes the responsibility of leading people seriously — who knows that every person on their team is somebody's most important person, and who tries to be worthy of that trust.

"People don't leave companies. They leave managers. The quality of management is the single biggest variable in whether employees stay, thrive, or quietly disengage."

— Marcus Buckingham & Curt Coffman, *First, Break All the Rules*

"The manager is the most important element in the employee experience. Not the culture. Not the leadership team. Not the perks. The person who assigns work, gives feedback, develops capability, and either creates or destroys psychological safety every day."

— Gallup, *State of the American Manager*

Preface

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Why HR for Every Manager™

HR is too important to leave entirely to HR professionals. The daily experience of work — what makes it energizing or draining, fulfilling or frustrating, fair or unjust — is determined almost entirely by the quality of a person's relationship with their direct manager. Not the organization's culture statement. Not the CEO's vision. The person who assigns their work, gives them feedback, advocates for their development, and either makes them feel valued or makes them feel expendable.

This book gives managers the practical, evidence-based knowledge they need to do that job well. The MANAGE Model™ — Motivate, Align, Nurture, Assess, Guide, Enable — provides the framework. Fifteen chapters provide the practical detail: what to do, why it works, and how to do it in the specific, messy, real-world context of leading a team.

Mayur N Koikar

Author, The HR Mastery Series™

Introduction

Why People Management Is the Most Consequential Skill You Will Ever Develop

"The quality of management determines the quality of work life for most people in most organizations. Get management right and almost everything else follows. Get it wrong and almost nothing else compensates."

— Adapted from Gallup, State of the Global Workplace 2024

Gallup's research across more than 195 countries and thirty-five million employees reaches the same conclusion year after year: seventy percent of the variance in team engagement is attributable to the manager. Not the organization's culture, not the HR programs, not the physical workspace — the manager.

That statistic is either inspiring or alarming, depending on the quality of management in your organization. For organizations with great managers, it means that every investment in management quality compounds across every team those managers lead. For organizations with poor or mediocre managers, it means that every other people investment — talent acquisition, learning and development, total rewards — is systematically underperforming because of management quality.

The MANAGE Model™ — A Complete People Management Framework

• M — MOTIVATE: Understanding what genuinely motivates each individual on your team and creating the conditions — autonomy, mastery, purpose, recognition, fair treatment — in which they can bring their best.

• A — ALIGN: Ensuring every team member clearly understands what the team is trying to achieve, how their specific role contributes to it, and what success looks like for them in their current role.

• N — NURTURE: Actively developing the capability of each team member — through coaching, feedback, stretch opportunities, and genuine investment in their long-term growth.

• A — ASSESS: Regularly, honestly, and fairly evaluating individual and team performance — not just in formal review cycles but in the continuous, evidence-based assessment that great management requires.

• G — GUIDE: Providing clear direction, honest feedback, and the coaching support people need to navigate difficulty — both the difficulty of the work and the difficulty of organizational life.

• E — ENABLE: Removing the obstacles — organizational, interpersonal, process-related — that prevent your team from doing their best work. The manager as obstacle-remover, resource-provider, and organizational navigator.

PART I

Foundations

Chapter 1

The Manager's Role — What It Really Means to Lead People

"Management is not about being in charge. It is about taking care of those in your charge."

— Simon Sinek, *Leaders Eat Last*

Jordan Ellery: From Top Analyst to Team Manager Overnight

Jordan Ellery was the strongest performer on Renwick Digital's client analytics team for three years before being promoted to manage that same six-person team — the people who were peers a week earlier. Jordan's first instinct is to keep doing the analytical work that earned the promotion, just faster and for more accounts, while treating management as something that happens in the gaps. By the end of week two, two direct reports have quietly gone to HRBP Priya Osei with the same complaint: Jordan is impossible to reach, reviews their work control-freak style, and hasn't asked either of them a single question about their goals. Priya's response reframes the entire chapter's argument for Jordan: the job changed completely the day the title did — Jordan is no longer paid to produce the best analysis, but to enable six other people to produce theirs.

Manager Mistake #1: Managing Like an Individual Contributor

A newly promoted manager continued spending most of their week doing hands-on technical work themselves, treating people management as an interruption to their "real job."

Within two quarters, team output had not meaningfully improved despite the manager working longer hours than ever, and an engagement survey showed the team felt unsupported and unclear on expectations — because the person now responsible for enabling their work was still trying to do it for them.

Lesson: the transition from doer to enabler is the single hardest and most consequential shift in a manager's first year — and skipping it quietly caps both the manager's and the team's performance.

Decision Tree: Am I managing, or just doing my old job with extra meetings?

Do you spend more hours each week on hands-on individual work than on your team's development, clarity, and removing blockers? -> You are likely still operating as an individual contributor with a manager's title. Could your team clearly state, right now, what you expect of them this month? -> If not, time spent on your own output is coming at the direct expense of a core management responsibility. When something goes wrong on the team, is your first instinct to fix it yourself or to coach the responsible person to fix it? -> Fixing it yourself repeatedly is a strong signal you haven't made the doing-to-enabling shift. If your week is genuinely centered on enabling others' work rather than replacing it -> You have made the core transition; focus on refining how well you do it.

Manager Toolkit: Making the Transition

MANAGER TOOLKIT: MAKING THE TRANSITION

New Manager Self-Audit — a short reflection tool to name what you're still doing yourself that you should now be enabling.

Role Clarity One-Pager — a simple document stating your team's purpose, your expectations, and how you'll measure success, to share in your first week.

Peer-to-Manager Conversation Guide — talking points for the (often awkward) first one-to-one with a former peer now reporting to you.

Manager Mistake #2: Avoiding the Peer-to-Manager Conversation

Promoted managers often avoid directly naming the shift in relationship with former peers, hoping it will resolve itself. It rarely does — name the change directly, acknowledge it may feel strange for both of you, and invite questions rather than letting the awkwardness fester unaddressed.

AI Manager Assistant

Prompt: "Help me draft talking points for my first one-to-one with a direct report who used to be my peer." Prompt: "Summarize the core responsibilities of a first-time people manager in plain language." Use AI to prepare and structure these conversations — but have them yourself, in your own words; a former peer will notice a scripted or impersonal tone immediately.

Visual Framework: The MANAGE Model™ Overview

VISUAL FRAMEWORK: THE MANAGE MODEL™ OVERVIEW

Motivate: Understand and activate what genuinely drives each person on your team.

Align: Set clear expectations and goals connected to real priorities.

Nurture: Develop capability through coaching, feedback, and growth opportunities.

Address: Handle underperformance and difficult situations directly and humanely.

Give Feedback: Make feedback frequent, specific, and two-directional.

Elevate: Build a team culture that outperforms what any single manager could produce alone.

The Fundamental Shift — From Doing to

Enabling

The most common reason for management failure is not incompetence or malice — it is that the promoted manager has never made the fundamental shift from individual contributor to people leader. As an individual contributor, success is measured by what you personally produce. As a manager, success is measured by what your team produces — and the highest-performing managers are those who have learned to subordinate their own task preferences to the enabling of others' best work.

Five Truths Every New Manager Must Accept

• YOUR JOB IS NOW TO MAKE OTHERS SUCCESSFUL: Your performance is measured by your team's performance. Hoarding the interesting work, solving problems your team members should solve, or making yourself indispensable through task ownership — all are management failure patterns.

• RELATIONSHIPS ARE YOUR PRIMARY TOOL: Every significant management outcome — performance improvement, development, retention, team cohesion — is achieved through the quality of relationships you build, not the quality of your technical expertise.

• YOU WILL NOT LIKE EVERY TEAM MEMBER EQUALLY: Professional management means treating every team member with equal respect and fairness regardless of personal affinity. The team member who challenges you most is often the one growing most rapidly.

• YOU ARE ALWAYS MODELING: Your team mirrors your behavior — your attitude to the organization, your treatment of colleagues, your standards of work quality, and your behavior under pressure. What you model is what you get.

• MANAGEMENT IS A SKILL, NOT A STATUS: Good management requires exactly the same investment of deliberate practice and continuous learning as any other complex professional skill. New managers who believe they already know how to manage rarely become great managers.

Key Takeaways

• The MANAGE Model™: Motivate, Align, Nurture, Assess, Guide, Enable.

• The fundamental shift: from doing to enabling. Management success is team success.

• Five management truths: your job is enabling others, relationships are your primary tool, model what you want, management is a skill not a status.

HR Mastery Audit: The Manager's Role

HR MASTERY AUDIT: THE MANAGER'S ROLE

- I can state, in one sentence, how my role changed the day I became a manager.
- My team could accurately describe what I expect of them this month.
- I spend more time enabling my team's work than doing it myself.
- I have had a direct, explicit conversation about the shift with any former peers now reporting to me.
- I know which of my current habits are still individual-contributor habits, not manager habits.

Score: 0-20 Needs Redesign | 21-40 Developing | 41-60 Good | 61-80 Excellent | 81-100 World Class.

Monday Morning Action Plan

MONDAY MORNING ACTION PLAN

1. Write one sentence describing how your role changed the day you became a manager.
2. List the three things you did last week that your team should have owned instead.
3. Schedule a direct conversation with any former peer now reporting to you, if you haven't yet.
4. Draft a one-page statement of your team's purpose and your expectations.
5. Identify one recurring task you can hand off this week to start the doing-to-enabling shift.

The 100-Day Manager Blueprint

Whether you're a first-time manager or stepping into a new team, this week-by-week blueprint gives you exactly what to focus on for your first 100 days.

THE 100-DAY MANAGER BLUEPRINT

Week 1: Listen and observe. Meet each team member one-on-one; ask about their role, priorities, and what they need from you. Make no major changes yet.

Week 2: Understand the work. Review current goals, projects, and processes. Identify what's working and what isn't, without acting on it yet.

Week 3: Set initial expectations. Share your working style and initial priorities; invite questions and concerns openly.

Week 4: Establish your rhythm. Launch consistent one-to-ones and a team meeting cadence you intend to sustain long-term.

Week 5: Identify quick wins. Find one or two visible improvements you can make that build early credibility.

Week 6: Assess team capability. Map current skills and gaps against what the team needs to deliver.

Week 7: Address the most urgent issue. If something is clearly broken, begin fixing it now rather than waiting.

Week 8: Deepen relationships. Have a more personal one-to-one with each team member about their career goals.

Week 9: Calibrate your management style. Reflect honestly on what's working and adjust your approach based on early feedback.

Week 10: Set 90-day goals. Establish clear, specific goals for the team's next quarter.

Week 11: Build your development plans. Draft an Individual Development Plan for at least one team member.

Week 12: Review your first quarter honestly. What has improved? What hasn't? Adjust your plan for the next 90 days.

Week 13: Strengthen team culture. Take one deliberate action to build trust and cohesion across the team.

Week 14: Look ahead. Set your own personal development goals as a manager for the next quarter, and share your team's direction with your own manager.

Chapter 2

What Motivates People — The Science Managers Need

"If you don't understand what motivates the people on your team, you are managing by assumption. And assumption is the enemy of effective management."

— Adapted from Dan Pink, *Drive*

Jordan Ellery: Assuming Everyone Wants What Jordan Wants

Jordan, motivated primarily by visible recognition and advancement, assumes the team shares the same priorities and starts publicly praising output and pushing everyone toward stretch assignments. One team member, a senior analyst nearing retirement, quietly disengages — stretch assignments and public praise mean little to someone motivated by stability and mastery of a craft they already love. Priya Osei's coaching prompt reframes Jordan's approach: run a short, direct conversation with each team member about what actually matters to them, rather than assuming the team is a mirror of Jordan's own motivations. The resulting one-to-ones surface four distinct motivational profiles across six people — a discovery that reshapes how Jordan assigns work and gives recognition from that point on.

Manager Mistake #3: Motivating Everyone the Same Way

A manager who was strongly motivated by public recognition assumed the entire team felt the same way, and built a recognition approach entirely around public praise and leaderboards.

Engagement scores for several quieter, mastery-motivated team members actually declined, because the public format felt uncomfortable rather than motivating to them — the manager had designed a one-size motivation strategy around personal preference rather than the team's actual, varied preferences.